crews. In 1885, true to his aquatic interests, Burnside accepted the position of professor of mathematics in the Royal Naval College at Greenwich, where he taught until retirement. When his enthusiasm for rowing subsided, fishing became Burnside's favorite hobby. Even in mathematical research he stayed close to water, making major contributions to hydrodynamics.

On the strength of his contributions to mathematical physics and complex function theory, Burnside was elected to the Royal Society in 1893. Once this worthy goal was achieved, however, he abandoned such trifle subjects and dipped into the theory of groups. Four years later Burnside published the first English textbook on the subject, *Theory of Groups of Finite Order*. He was apparently delighted to take a break from applied studies and to immerse himself in an abstract theory, for he wrote in the preface: "The present treatise is intended to introduce to the reader the main outlines of the theory of groups of finite order apart from any applications". Burnside noted that group theory was not yet particularly popular in England. "It will afford me much satisfaction", he remarked, "if, by means of this book, I shall succeed in arousing interest among English mathematicians in a branch of pure mathematics which becomes the more fascinating the more it is studied" (quoted in [**11**, pp. 88-89]).

The interest of English mathematicians, however, proved not to be easily aroused, and ten years later Burnside bitterly remarked in his retiring Presidential address to the London Mathematical Society: "It is undoubtedly the fact that the theory of groups of finite order has failed, so far, to arouse the interest of any but a very small number of English mathematicians". Burnside cited the proliferation of courses on group theory in France, the United States, and especially Germany (attended by thirty students in Göttingen!), and he lamented the total indifference of British students toward the subject. His explanation was that group theory was treated in a highly abstract manner, "one which the young mind grasps with difficulty, if at all". As an example, Burnside cited a formal statement about the properties of the icosahedral group and claimed that "a proposal to verify the statement appears equivalent to proposing a series of conundrums. There would be nothing here to attract the student or